

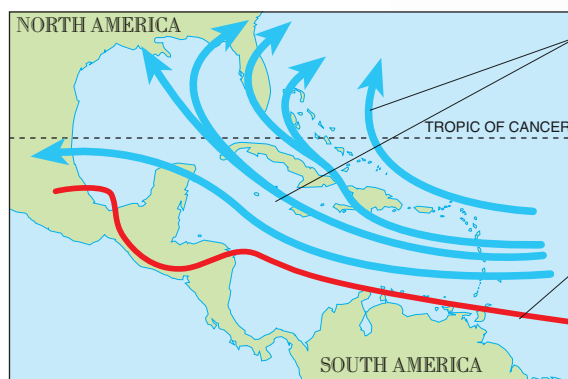
CENTRAL AMERICA AND THE CARIBBEAN

THE SEVEN SMALL COUNTRIES OF CENTRAL AMERICA lie within a neck of land that joins North and South America. To the east, hundreds of Caribbean islands stretch from the US almost to Venezuela. When Christopher Columbus and his Spanish crew dropped anchor in the Caribbean in 1492, they thought it was Asia, and the islands became known as the West Indies. From that time on, Europeans competed for control of the region, bringing slaves from Africa to work on the land. Central America's greatest influence is still Spanish, while the Caribbean retains its African culture. The entire area is affected by natural hazards, with volcanoes, earthquakes, and hurricanes.



FARMING THE LAND

Even before the arrival of Europeans, Central America was an agricultural region. The land divides into three main zones: the fertile Pacific plain, ideal for growing crops such as bananas; the central highlands, with coffee plantations (above) and cattle ranches; and the forested northeast, where the soil is less suitable for farming. Intensive farming has damaged much of the environment.



Arrows indicate the movements of storms and show how they die out once they hit land and "spend" all their energy.

The red line across the map marks the southern limit of the area of hurricane activity.

HURRICANE STRENGTH

Powerful tropical storms known as hurricanes affect the Caribbean between May and October. A hurricane starts off as a normal storm over the ocean, but grows in force if the waters are particularly warm. Winds then blow the swirling mass of cloud, wind, and rain westward, toward the islands, where it can cause massive destruction when it hits land. The word hurricane comes from Huracan, the local name for the god of storms.



CUBA



Havana, Cuba

Jan 72°F (22°C)
July 82°F (28°C)

Jan 2.8 in (71 mm)
July 4.9 in (125 mm)

